

PRODUCT CASE STUDY

Aura Velocity

The Temporal Intelligence Terminal

A Personal Intelligence System for Time and Energy Allocation

Role	Stack	Status	Built with
End-to-End Product Strategy & AI-Native Development	React 19 + Firebase + Gemini AI	Live · existence-stream.web.app	Vibe Coding + Claude + ChatGPT

01 — THE ORIGIN STORY

Where It Started: An Honest Frustration

Before Aura Velocity existed, there was just a person staring at an Excel sheet trying to figure out where his day had gone.

As an MBA student from IIM Ranchi with an engineering background, I found myself in a contradiction: I had the frameworks to think about efficiency, but my personal life was running on chaos. I had no rhythm, no routine, and no clear picture of how I was spending my time. I would end most days feeling busy, but unable to explain where the time had gone, not tired from doing meaningful things but occupied by fragmented work that rarely felt meaningful.

"I kept ending my days thinking I could have done so much more. I just didn't understand where my time was going."

The first solution was embarrassingly simple: a colour-coded Excel sheet. I tracked my daily activities manually what I did, when, and for how long. It worked, barely. But it was not sustainable, not aesthetic, and not intelligent. It told me what happened. It couldn't tell me why it mattered, or what to do about it.

I looked at existing productivity apps — Google Calendar, Notion, Todoist, various habit trackers. Every one of them had the same flaw: they told you what to add. More tasks, more reminders, more structure. None of them asked the more important question: what should you stop doing?

That gap between knowing you're busy and actually being productive — became the product.

The Founding Insight

Most productivity tools are graveyards of things you'll never do. The real problem isn't under-scheduling — it's over-tolerating. You don't need more tasks. You need a system capable of identifying what no longer deserves your attention.

[Live Link](#)

Four Persistent Productivity Failure Modes

Through my own usage and observation, I identified four distinct productivity failure modes that existing tools were not designed to solve:

1. The Silent Time Leak

High performers often feel busy but unproductive. The culprit is what I call "Boondoggles" — low-value, low-regret activities that quietly consume peak energy hours. They don't feel wasteful in the moment. They accumulate. Most tools don't even try to identify them because they're optimised for task completion, not task quality.

2. Circadian Misalignment

Every person has a biological energy curve — periods of peak cognitive performance tied to their chronotype. A "Vampire" (late-night peak) doing deep technical work at 9 AM is working against their own biology. Calendars schedule by time, not by energy. Most scheduling systems optimise for clock time rather than cognitive readiness.

3. Financial Fog

A static bank balance tells you nothing strategic. The meaningful number is Runway — how many days can you sustain your current lifestyle if income stops tomorrow? Without this, financial decisions are emotional rather than tactical.

4. Relationship Decay

Founders and builders often wake up to discover that months have passed since they spoke to people who matter — mentors, collaborators, close friends. There is no system nudging them. Relationships are Social Capital, and like all capital, they decay without maintenance. Most relationship decay happens gradually and invisibly, which makes proactive visibility more valuable than reactive reminders.

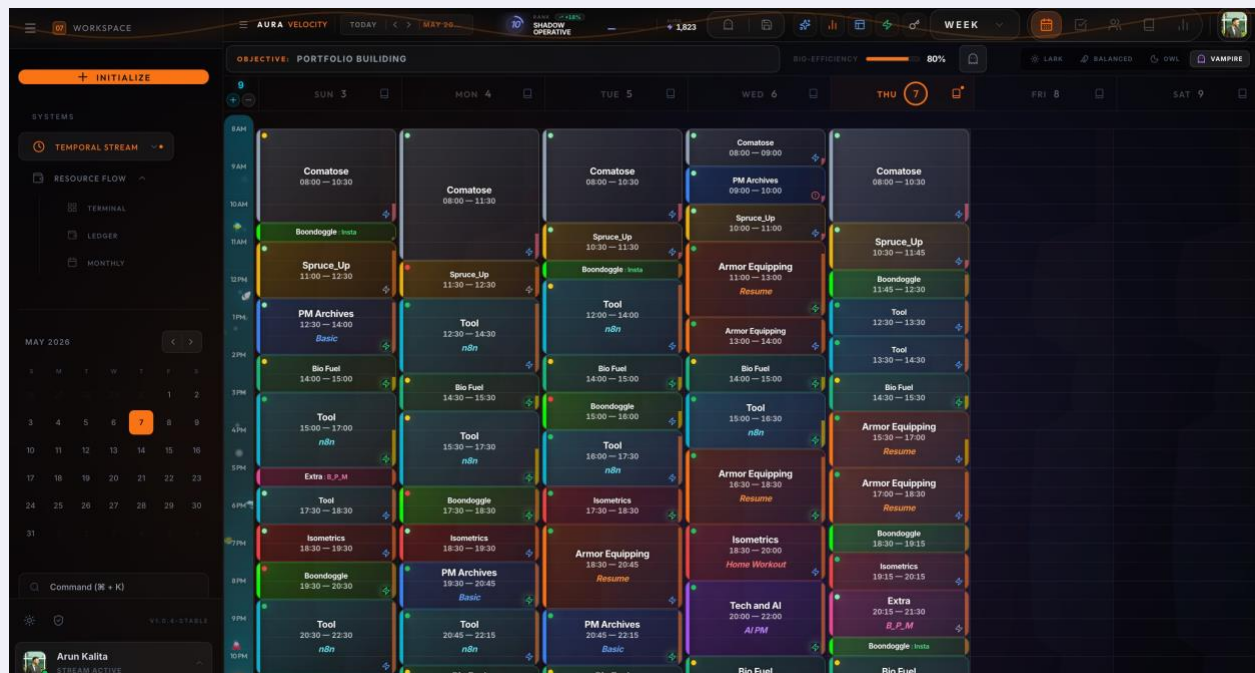
Problem	Root Cause	What Tools Do Today
Time Leakage	No visibility into low-value habits	Add more reminders
Circadian Misalignment	Schedule ignores biology	Time blocks only
Financial Fog	Balance ≠ Runway	Transaction tracking
Relationship Decay	No maintenance system	Separate CRM apps

03 — THE PRODUCT

What Aura Velocity Is

Aura Velocity is a Temporal Intelligence Terminal — a high-performance Life Operating System that treats time, energy, relationships, and finance as a unified "Life Capital" ledger. It is not a calendar. It is not a habit tracker. It is a decision engine for personal resource allocation.

The product is live and accessible at existence-stream.web.app, built on React 19, Firebase, and Gemini AI, shipped end-to-end through AI-assisted engineering workflows.



Dashboard Overview

Main screen — Temporal Timeline, Aura Score, and active activity blocks

The Core Philosophy: Via Negativa

Aura Velocity is built on a single philosophical bet that runs counter to the entire productivity industry: subtraction is more valuable than addition. The most important question is not "What should I do today?" but "What should I stop doing?" This principle became the foundation for the product's decision-making model.

Product Evolution: How It Was Built

The product evolved through progressive narrowing rather than feature expansion. Each iteration removed weaker ideas and strengthened the core behavioural thesis.

[Live Link](https://existence-stream.web.app)

Phase	Name	Key Insight / What Was Built
1	LifeApp	Tracking "Regret" is more motivating than tracking "Progress." Started with an Excel sheet; moved to a basic time-logger. People are often more consistent at avoiding wasted time than pursuing abstract productivity goals.
2	LifeOS	Time is zero-sum. Built the Temporal Integrity Engine — recursive exclusivity logic ensuring no two activities occupy the same time block.
3	Aura Pulse	Introduced the Aura Score — a gamified alignment metric that rewards scheduling high-intensity tasks during peak biological energy.
4	Aura Velocity	Full Life Capital suite. Added AI Subtraction Engine (Gemini), Personal CRM, Finance Terminal (Resource Flow), Ghost Mode, and the Mechanical UI.

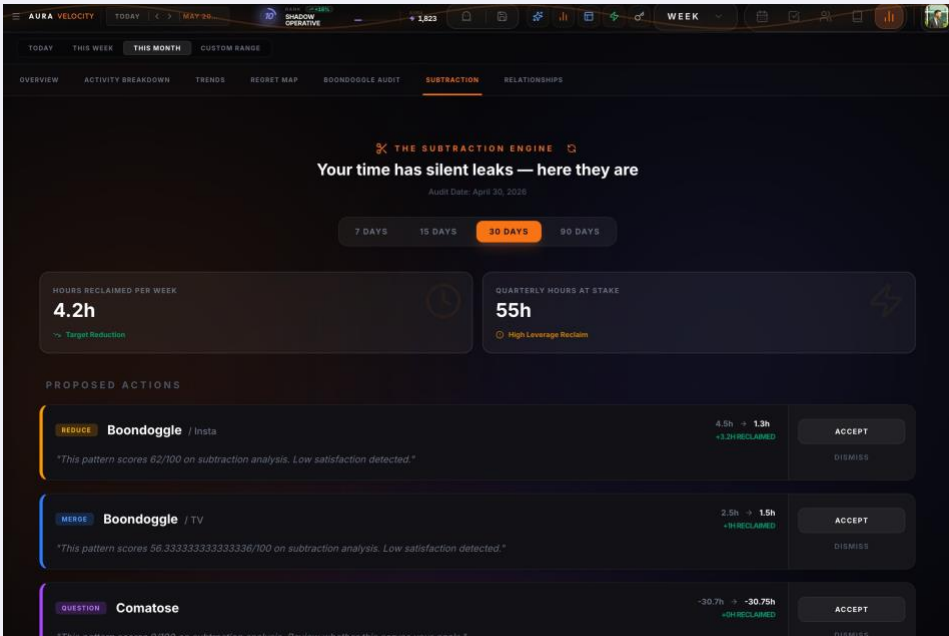
04 — CORE FEATURES & PRODUCT THINKING

Each feature in Aura Velocity exists because of a specific, reasoned product decision, not because it was easy to build. Below is the feature inventory with the PM reasoning behind each one.

Feature	What It Does & Why It Exists	Type
Subtraction Engine	AI-powered (Gemini) audit of activity logs. Analyses patterns and proposes Purges, Reductions, or Merges for low-value habits. Users often tolerate recurring low-value behaviours because the individual cost feels small in isolation. Core behavioural differentiation layer focused on identifying low-value activity patterns.	AI Core
Temporal Integrity Engine	Recursive algorithm ensuring no two activities overlap. Implements a greedy forward-push cascade — if you add a task that conflicts, the engine resolves it automatically. Treats time as a zero-sum, non-negotiable resource.	Core Logic
Circadian Engine	Maps 4 chronotypes (Lark, Owl, Balanced, Vampire) to activity intensity. The model intentionally simplifies energy behaviour into broad categories to preserve usability and fast onboarding. Calculates the Aura Score based on alignment between task intensity and biological energy peak.	Intelligence
Aura Score	XP-based gamification layer. Rewards alignment decisions, not just task completion. Designed to make good scheduling habits feel earned rather than enforced. The intention was to reinforce scheduling quality rather than maximise task volume.	Engagement
Resource Flow	Personal finance reframed as startup capital. Tracks Burn Rate (daily cost of living) and Runway (days until zero liquidity). Liquidity Pulse visualisation creates an emotional connection to financial health.	Capital

Personal CRM	Relationship decay prevention system. Tracks last contact date by tier — close, professional, acquaintance. Nudges proactively before relationships go cold.	Social Capital
Ghost Mode	Planned schedule vs. actual logs. Surfaces the gap between intent and reality — the single most honest data point in any productivity system. The feature was designed to encourage reflection rather than punishment. The goal is awareness of behavioural drift, not productivity guilt.	Insight
Mechanical UI	Every log entry triggers a tactile "clunk" sound and screen micro-feedback. This introduces slight interaction friction intentionally. Faster logging was considered less important than reinforcing awareness around time allocation. Designed to raise the psychological cost of each time decision.	UX Philosophy

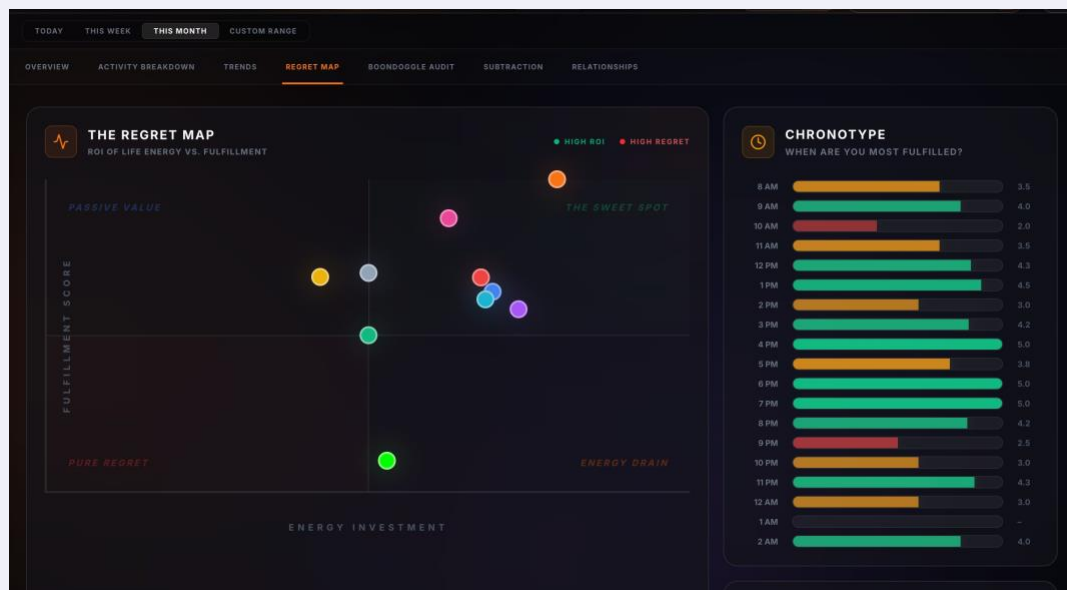
Each system in Aura Velocity feeds another — time logs inform behavioural audits, chronotype alignment shapes scoring, and Ghost Mode closes the gap between intention and reality.



Subtraction Engine — Audit Output

AI-generated Purge/Reduce/Merge proposals after 30 days of activity data

PM Reasoning: Why "Mechanical" Feedback?
Most productivity apps make logging frictionless. Aura Velocity makes it deliberate. The clunk sound is not decoration — it is a micro-commitment mechanism. Every time you log an activity and hear that sound, your brain registers: this time was spent. That accountability loop is the retention engine.



Aura Score & Circadian Alignment View

Chronotype overlay — Regret Map and hourly fulfillment scores

05 — USERS & JOBS TO BE DONE

Primary Persona: The "Vampire" Founder

Works late, AI-native, obsessed with efficiency. Views their time as the single highest-leverage resource they control. Not looking for a softer calendar, looking for a more intentional decision environment.

Emotional driver: The fear of "drifting", reaching the end of a year and realising they lived on accidental habits rather than intentional design.

Job To Be Done (Primary)

"When I feel my week slipping away into low-value meetings and distractions, I want to run a Subtraction Audit so that I can systematically reduce the low value activities and protect my high-leverage focus hours."

Secondary Persona: The Technical PM / "The Architect"

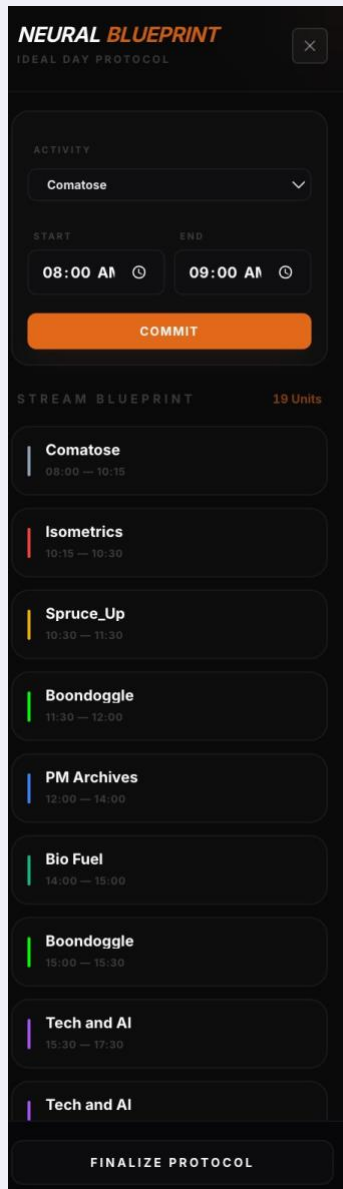
Age 24–40. Data-driven self-improvement. High autonomy. Wants to manage every dimension of life — time, money, people, energy from a single interface without app-hopping.

Emotional driver: Hates inefficiency. Derives satisfaction from systems that work precisely. Wants the digital to feel as consequential as the physical.

[Live Link](#)

06 — USER JOURNEY

Stage	What Happens	Product Decision Behind It
Discovery	User encounters the Subtraction Manifesto. The idea that a productivity tool should tell you what to cut — not what to add — creates immediate differentiation.	Lead with philosophy, not features. People buy into a worldview before they buy into a product.
Onboarding	User sets their Chronotype (Lark, Owl, Balanced, or Vampire) and initialises "Armor Equipping" tasks. The UI uses elite naming immediately — sleep is "Comatose," meals are "Bio Fuel."	Onboarding is identity formation. By naming your chronotype, you're not just setting up a tool — you're claiming a category of person.
Activation	User logs their first Deep Work session. They hear the mechanical clunk. The Aura Score updates. Biological alignment is immediately visible.	The first Aha Moment must be emotional, not informational. The clunk + score update creates a feedback loop in under 60 seconds.
Engagement	Daily log → Regret Rating → Weekly Aura Score review. Ghost Mode surfaces the gap between planned and actual. Patterns emerge.	Retention is built on honest data. Ghost Mode is uncomfortable on purpose — the delta between intent and reality is what drives change.
Retention	After 30 days, the Subtraction Engine proposes its first audit. User sees specific "Boondoggle" activities eating 10–15 hours per week.	The 30-day Subtraction Proposal is the product's highest-value moment. Everything before it is data collection. This is the payoff.



Ghost Mode / Neural Blueprint

Ideal day blueprint — planned schedule protocol view

07 — TECHNICAL ARCHITECTURE (PM LENS)

As a non-developer, every architectural decision I made had a product reason behind it. The following is not a code walkthrough — it is a story of technical tradeoffs made in service of the user experience.

[Live Link](#)

The Dual-Mirror Sync Strategy

The app uses two layers of persistence: LocalStorage for immediate, zero-latency interaction, and Firebase Firestore for background cloud sync. The product implication: every interaction feels native and instant, even on a slow connection — interactions remain responsive even under poor connectivity. This was a deliberate tradeoff — complexity in the sync layer in exchange for a premium, app-like feel on the web.

The Heal Engine

The Heal Engine is a custom reconciliation algorithm that prevents overlapping activity logs and resolves sync conflicts across devices. Product reasoning: time is the core data model of this product. Any inconsistency in the time log would undermine the entire credibility of the Subtraction Engine's output. Data integrity here is not a technical concern — it is a trust concern.

AI as a Forensic Auditor, Not a Chatbot

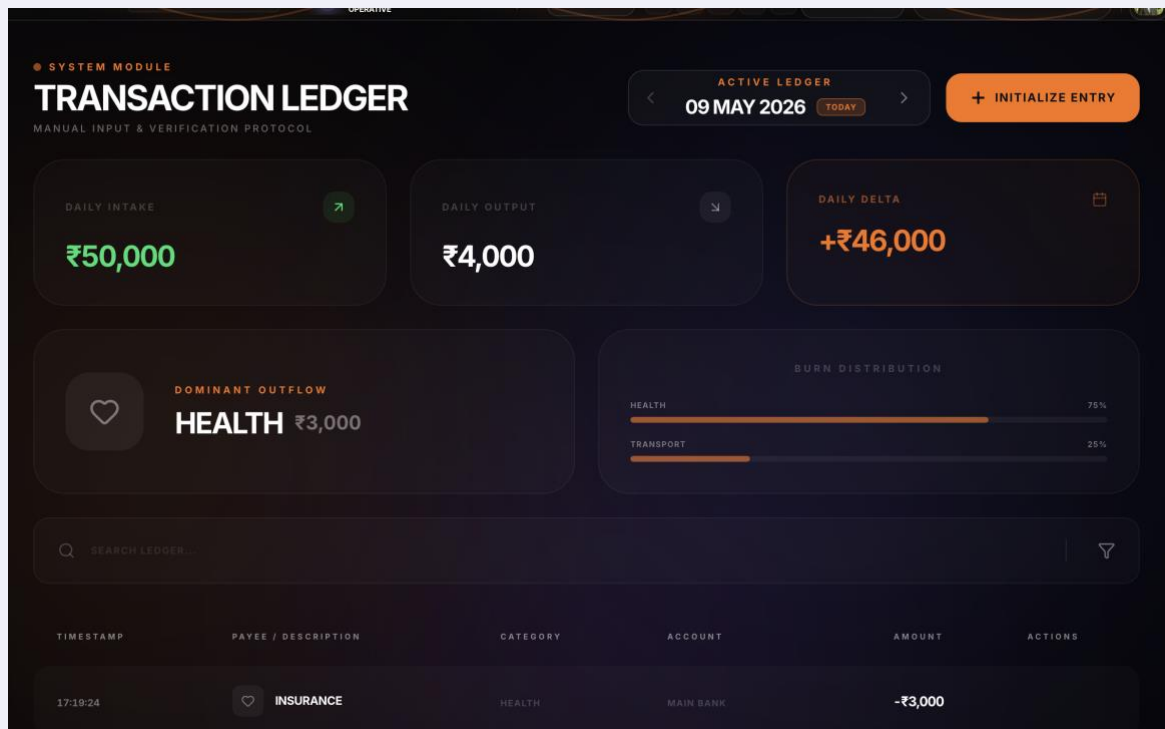
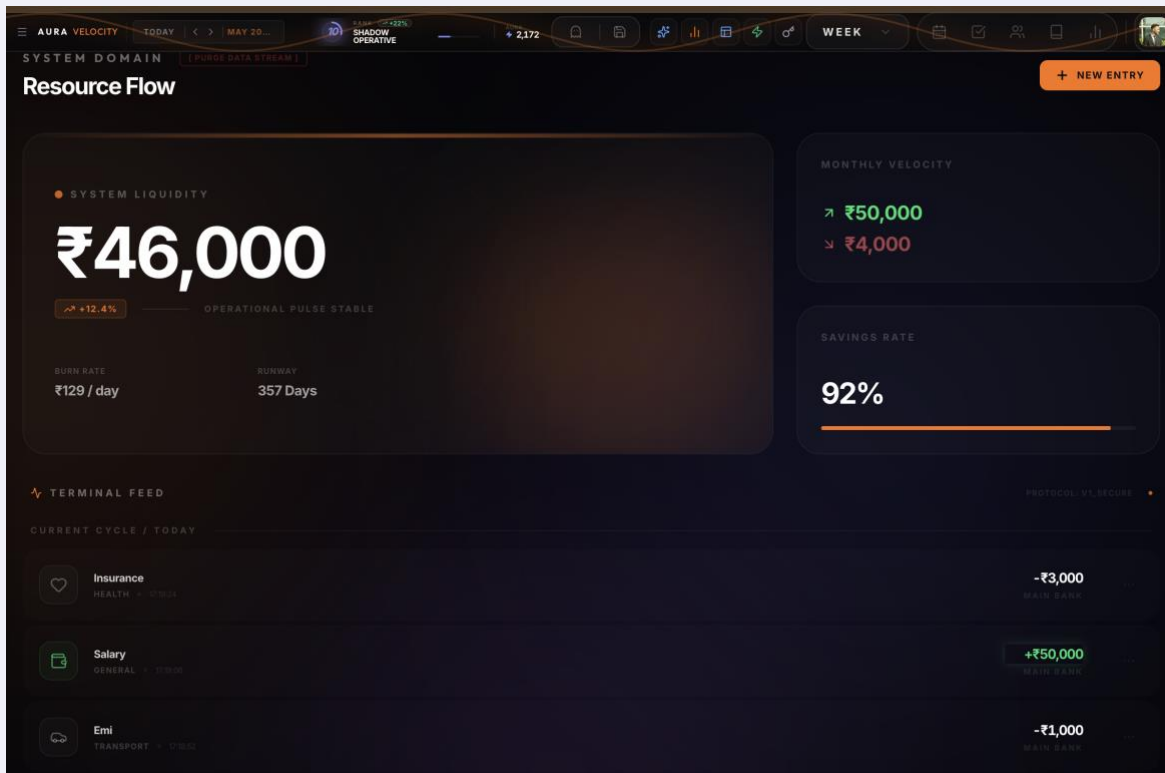
Gemini 1.5 Flash was integrated via surgical JSON prompts — not as a conversational interface, but as a backend processor. The AI receives a structured dump of the user's activity logs, regret ratings, and circadian alignment data. It returns a Subtraction Proposal: a specific list of Purges, Reductions, and Merges. This is a deliberate AI product decision: the value is in the output quality, not the interaction mode. The AI layer was intentionally scoped narrowly — the goal was not continuous conversation, but higher-quality behavioural analysis with predictable outputs.

Critically, every AI feature has a local fallback. If the API is unavailable, the app continues to function. AI enriches the product — it is not a dependency.

Building Through AI-Native Workflows

Aura Velocity was built entirely without a traditional engineering background. The stack — React 19, Vite, Tailwind, Framer Motion, Firebase, and Gemini — was navigated using Claude, ChatGPT, and vibe coding tools. This also shaped the way the product evolved. From 2025, the barrier between product thinking and product shipping has effectively collapsed for anyone willing to learn the new tools. This project is proof of that.

Layer	Technology	Product Reason
Frontend	React 19 + Vite + Tailwind	Performance as a feature — zero-latency UI
State	LocalStorage + Firestore	Offline-first, native feel on the web
AI	Gemini 1.5 Flash	Forensic auditor — not conversational AI
Auth	Firebase Google OAuth	Frictionless onboarding, identity-first
Animations	Framer Motion	Mechanical UI requires 60fps feedback



Resource Flow — Liquidity Pulse & Runway

Finance Terminal showing Burn Rate, Runway days, and System Liquidity

08 — METRICS & IMPACT

North Star Metric

Hours Reclaimed Per Month — the total time identified as low-value and removed from the user's schedule via the Subtraction Engine. This is the clearest indicator of whether the product is creating behavioural value.

Every other metric in the product exists in service of this number.

Supporting Metrics

- Aura Score Trend — is the user's biological alignment improving week over week?
- Mechanical Hits Per Day — log frequency. Baseline signal for engagement.
- Ghost Mode Delta — gap between planned and actual. A shrinking delta means the product is changing behaviour.
- Runway (Resource Flow) — days of financial freedom. A strategic health metric.

Impact (Based on Founder's Own Use)

Through regular use of the Subtraction Engine over 30 days, approximately 10–12 hours per week were identified as low-value "Boondoggle" activities — representing a ~30% reduction in time spent on tasks with high time investment but low personal value. These numbers reflect the founder's personal usage data and are shared as observed signals, not validated user research.

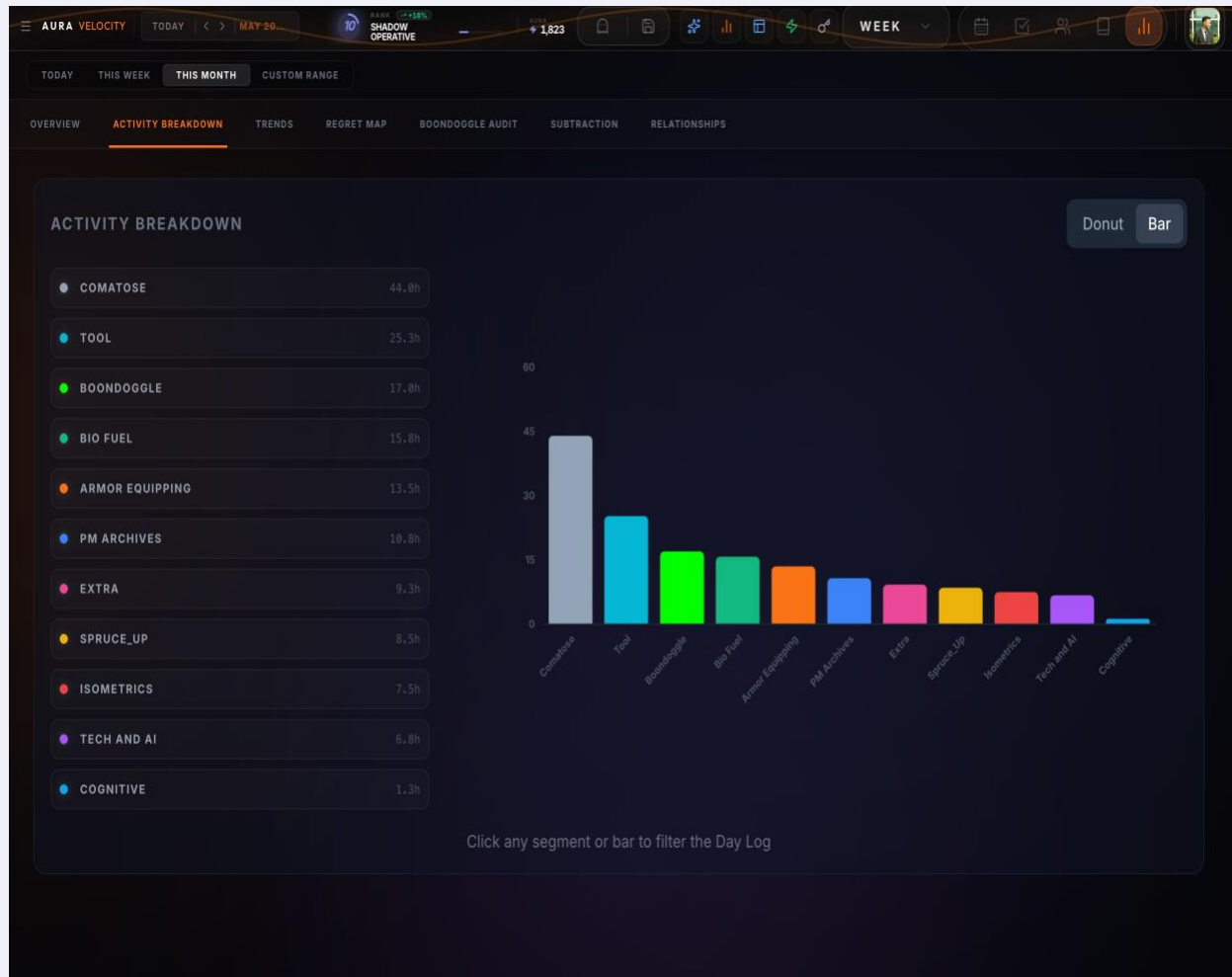
09 — DESIGN PHILOSOPHY

Industrial Brutalism Meets Glassmorphism

Aura Velocity deliberately avoids the soft, pastel aesthetic of mainstream SaaS productivity tools. The design language is high-density, high-contrast, and intentionally opinionated — because the target user is someone who finds most productivity apps patronising.

Key design decisions and their product reasoning:

- High-density layouts — more information per screen. The interface prioritizes information visibility over visual softness. Whitespace is not premium here; information is.
- Vertical timeline as Source of Truth — the day is read top-to-bottom, like a newspaper. The most important data is always visible.
- Identity-driven naming system — "Comatose" instead of sleep, "Armor Equipping" instead of morning routine, "Biofuel" instead of meals. Language is identity. The naming reinforces intentionality.
- Living backgrounds and micro-animations — represent biological flow. The interface breathes because the user's energy does too.

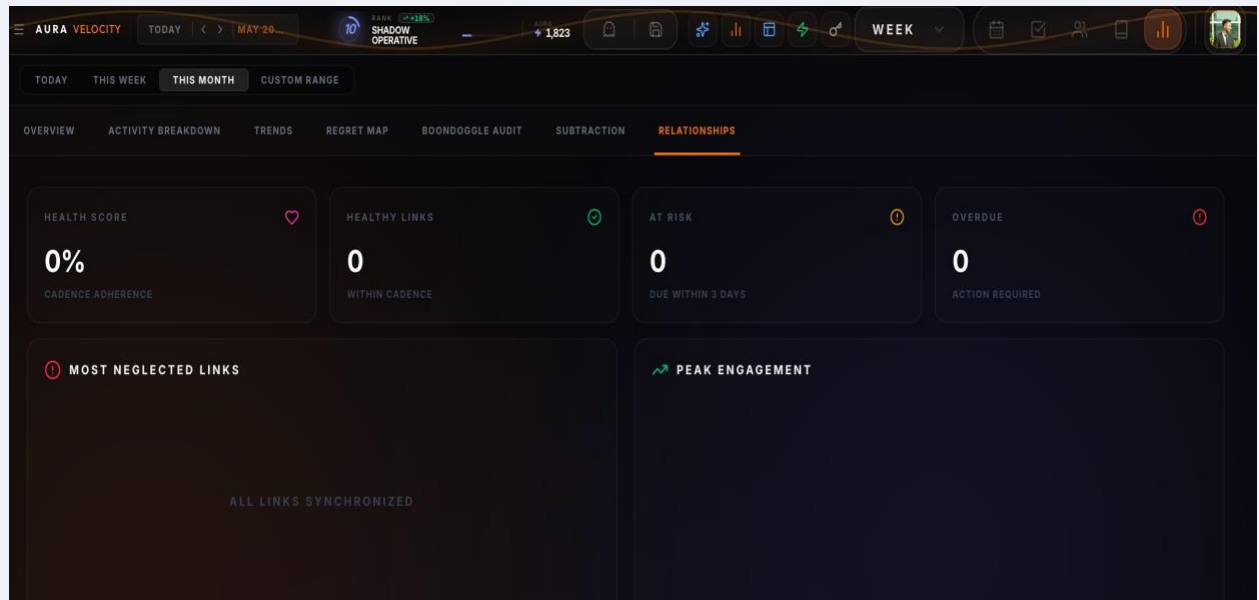


Life Capital Report — Activity Breakdown

Activity time breakdown showing Boondoggle vs. Deep Work distribution

Design Trade-off

High cognitive load for new users was a conscious choice, not an oversight. Aura Velocity is not optimised for onboarding conversion — it is optimised for power-user retention. The learning curve acts as a filter: only people serious about the philosophy get through it. This mirrors the product's core user persona.



Personal CRM — Relationship Cadence

Relationship health dashboard: Cadence Adherence, Healthy Links, and At-Risk contacts

10 — PRODUCT STRATEGY & MOAT

The Competitive Moat: Subtraction Logic

The entire productivity software market is built on addition. Todoist adds tasks. Notion adds pages. Google Calendar adds events. No mainstream tool is architecturally designed to remove things from your life.

Aura Velocity's moat is this: the Subtraction Engine is not a feature that can be easily bolted onto an existing productivity app. It requires a specific data model (Regret Ratings, activity logs with intensity and alignment scores), a specific AI prompting architecture (surgical JSON audits), and — most importantly — a specific philosophy. You cannot add a subtraction engine to a task manager. You must build the whole product around it.

Positioning Statement

For high performers who find traditional tools too "soft,"

Aura Velocity provides a tactile, high-density cockpit to manage their biological, temporal, and financial runway. Unlike Google Calendar or Notion, it doesn't just schedule your life — it audits it.

[Live Link](#)

Roadmap Vision

The roadmap is intentionally sequenced around behavioural coherence rather than rapid feature expansion. Aura Velocity's current version covers the four primary dimensions of Life Capital: Time, Energy, Money, and Relationships. The long-term vision is to complete the full human operating system across every major life domain:

- Learning & Growth — track books, courses, and skill acquisition as compounding intellectual capital.
- Health & Body — integrate fitness logs (currently a separate app, Fit 90) to create a unified biological performance view.
- Travel & Experiences — life runway isn't only financial; experiences are also a form of capital.
- Social Velocity (V3) — team-level Subtraction Audits for startups to identify organisational time leakage, meeting bloat, and focus drain.

11 — WHAT I LEARNED

As a Product Builder

- The best products are built to solve your own problem first. The fact that I used Aura Velocity every day during development meant every feature decision was grounded in real friction, not hypothetical user pain.
- Most meaningful product clarity emerged through iteration rather than upfront planning. The product went through four distinct identity shifts — LifeApp, LifeOS, Aura Pulse, Aura Velocity — before finding its voice. Each pivot was driven by a new insight, not a plan.
- Naming is product strategy. The shift from "sleep" to "Comatose" is not a cosmetic decision. It changes how users think about their data and themselves.

As an AI-Native Builder

AI tools have collapsed the gap between product thinking and product shipping. A non-CS engineer with an MBA was able to build and deploy a full-stack, AI-powered application — not despite his background, but because of it. Strong product reasoning combined with AI tooling dramatically compresses execution cycles.

- The "Vibe Coding" approach — using Claude and ChatGPT as collaborative engineering partners — mirrors how the best PMs will work in the next decade. You don't need to write every line of code. You need to know exactly what you're trying to build and why.

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existence-stream.web.app · React 19 + Firebase + Gemini AI ·